

4.2 Web Design Mistakes

Sometimes, designers get carried away by technology and the options at hand. Just because an option exists doesn't mean it has to be used.

Frames

The simplest example we can give here are frames. Five years ago, frames were the in thing—they let one or two parts of your site remain constant, while only one frame changed. This idea caught on like wildfire, and every second designer, at one point, was designing sites with frames. However, when content on the Web started to grow, search engines became more popular, and the concept of bookmarking caught on. Frames didn't gel well with bookmarks.

In the context of search, the concept of frames is itself flawed: it uses one HTML page that gets content from two or more other pages and places the content in pre-defined parts of the page. Though this sounds like a good idea, search robots will visit the index page and catalogue it as the content of your site—ignoring all the HTML code that refers to other pages. This led to sites with frames dropping rapidly in search engine rankings. This was perhaps the major reason why frames are no longer popular—after all, Search Engine Optimisation (SEO) is a full-time business now, and is also a major aspect of Web design.

A second flaw, but perhaps less influential towards the discontinuance of using frames, is that frames make it virtually impossible for a visitor to bookmark a particular page in your site. Since the current page is always the home page, and only specific frames within the page change, when a visitor chooses to bookmark the page, the browser always bookmarks the home page. Now, if visitors navigate a considerable amount within your Web site to get to where they are, and bookmark the current page only to return later and find that they have to navigate from your home page all the way back to where they were the first time, they are not going to be pleased!